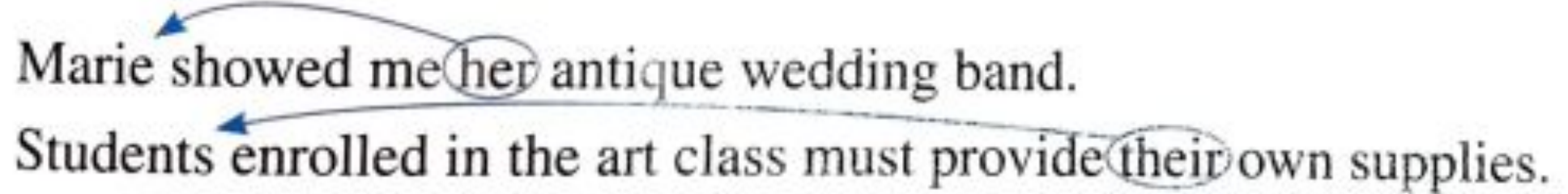


Pronoun Agreement & Pronoun Reference

A pronoun must agree in number with the word or words it replaces. If the word a pronoun refers to is singular, the pronoun must be singular; if that word is plural, the pronoun must be plural. The word a pronoun refers to is known as the **antecedent**.



Marie showed me her antique wedding band.
Students enrolled in the art class must provide their own supplies.

Exercise: Write the appropriate pronoun (their, they, them, it) in the blank space in each of the following sentences.

EXAMPLE: I opened the wet umbrella and put it in the bathtub to dry.

1. Kate and Omar left for the movies earlier than usual because ----- knew the theater would be packed.
2. The clothes were still damp, but I decided to fold -----anyway.
3. Many people immigrate to America to make a better life for ----- families.
4. Paul's grandparents renewed ----- marriage vows at huge fiftieth wedding anniversary celebration
5. The area around San Jose, California, produces fine wines, but ----- is also the home of many high- technology companies.

Indefinite Pronouns:

The following words, known as indefinite pronouns, are always singular.

(-one words)	(-body words)	
one	nobody	each
anyone	anybody	either
everyone	everybody	neither
someone	somebody	

If a pronoun in a sentence refers to one of these singular words, the pronoun should be singular.

Somebody left her shoulder bag on the back of a chair.
One of the busboys just called and said he would be an hour late.
Everyone in the club must pay his dues next week.

Each circled pronoun is singular because it refers to an indefinite pronoun.

Two important points to remember:

1. In the last example, if everyone in the club was a woman, the pronoun would be her. If the club had women and men, the pronoun would be his or her:

e.g.: Everyone in the club must pay his or her dues next week.

Traditionally, writers used **his** to refer to both women and men; however, most writers now use his or her to avoid an implied gender bias. To avoid using his or the somewhat awkward his or her, a sentence can often be rewritten in the plural: Club members must pay their dues next week

- 2. In informal spoken English, plural pronouns are often used with the indefinite pronouns.

Many people would probably not say :

Everybody has his or her own opinion about election.

Instead, they would likely to say,

Everybody has their own opinion about the election

Other examples :

1. Everyone in the choir must buy their robes.
2. Everybody in the line has their ticket ready.
3. No one in the class remembered to bring their books.

In such cases, the indefinite pronouns are clearly plural in meaning, and using **them** helps people avoid the awkward **his** or **her**

Identify the correct pronoun.

1. Each of the three sisters was willing to donate *(her, their)* inheritance to charity.
2. Everybody should bring *(his or her, their)* own camera to class next week.
3. Neither of the teachers had set up (his or her, their) classroom for the new school year.
4. All new skiers should expect *(his or her, their)* muscles to ache the next day.
5. Not one of the men had finished painting (his, their) section of the fence by the time it began to rain.

Pronoun Reference:

A sentence may be confusing or unclear if a pronoun appears to refer to more than one word or does not refer to any specific word.

- Unclear: Miriam was annoyed when they failed her car for a faulty turn sign.
- *Who* failed her car? There is no specific word that they refers to. Be clear.
- Fix: Miriam was annoyed when the inspectors failed her car for a faulty turn signal.

FAULTY	CLEAR
Kia is really a shy person, but she keeps it hidden. (There is no specific word that it refers to. It would not make sense to say, "Kia keeps shy hidden.")	Kia is really a shy person, but she keeps her shyness hidden.
Marsha attributed her success to her husband's support, which was generous. (Does which mean that Marsha's action was generous or that her husband's support was generous?)	Generously, Marsha attributed her success to her husband's support. Or: Marsha attributed her success to her husband's generous support.
Peter told Alan that his wife was unhappy. (Whose wife is unhappy: Peter's or Alan's?)	Peter told Alan, “ My wife was unhappy. “

Rewrite each of the following sentences to make clear the vague pronoun reference. Add, change, or omit words as necessary.

Example: Susan's mother wondered if she was tall enough to be a model.

Susan's mother wondered if Susan was tall enough to be a model.

1. Jim is a talkative person; sometimes he just can't control it.
2. At that fast-food restaurant, they give you free glasses with your soft drinks.
3. Sallie told Anna that she had just been promoted to assistant manager.
4. Dipping her spoon into the pot of simmering spaghetti sauce, Helen felt it slip out of her hand.
5. Pete visited the tutoring center because they can help him with his economics course.